

1755: THE SHATTERING OF ACADIE & MI'KMA'KI

A Forensic Investigation of Dykeland Engineering, Imperial Cleansing & The Guerilla Defense of the Maritimes

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Scope: Geopolitical Deconstruction, *Le Grand Dérangement*, Wabanaki Sovereignty, Aboiteau Hydraulics, Archival Genealogy

FORENSIC HISTORICAL DIRECTIVE: The catastrophe of 1755 in Nova Scotia (known in Acadian historiography as *Le Grand Dérangement*) is often romanticized as a tragic, passive pastoral exile. Primary archival records, engineering assessments of the Bay of Fundy, and British military correspondence reveal a different reality: it was a planned campaign of military deportation, land dispossession, and scorched-earth warfare. Executed under the direction of Lieutenant-Governor Charles Lawrence and New England commercial interests, the campaign targeted both the French-speaking Acadians—who had built a productive agricultural society on reclaimed salt marshes without clearing upland forests—and their allies, the Mi'kmaq, whose sovereign, unceded homeland of *Mi'kma'ki* stood in the way of British settlement. This manual examines the geopolitical drivers, civil engineering, military logistics, and joint Acadian-Mi'kmaw resistance surrounding the events of 1755.

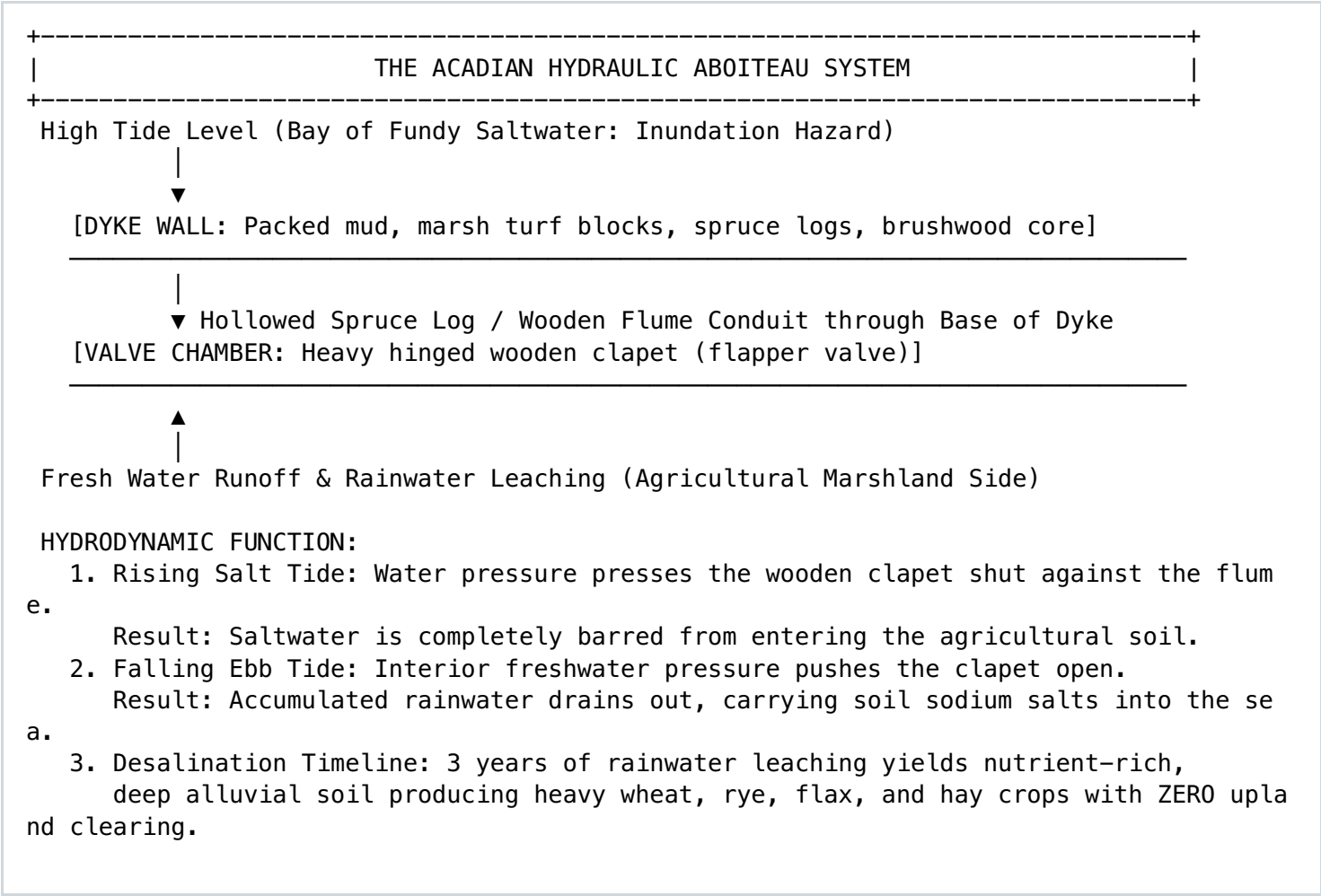
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1. THE LAND BEFORE THE FRACTURE: MI'KMA'KI & THE ABOITEAU CIVILISATION

Before European arrival, the maritime region was **Mi'kma'ki**, the ancestral, unceded territory of the Mi'kmaw nation, organized into seven traditional districts (including *Sipekne'katik*, *Siknikt*, and *Eskikewa'kik*) governed under the Santu Mawi'omi (Grand Council) and tied into the broader Wabanaki Confederacy.

When French settlers arrived in the early 17th century, they did not displace the Mi'kmaq through clear-cutting of hunting territories. Instead, the Acadians occupied the intertidal salt marshes of the Bay of Fundy (featuring the highest tidal ranges on earth, exceeding 16 meters), introducing a hydraulic technology adapted from western France: the **Aboiteau**.



This hydraulic strategy fostered a unique relationship between Acadians and the Mi'kmaq. Because Acadians farmed the intertidal mudflats rather than the inland forests, they avoided direct resource conflict with Mi'kmaw hunting economies. Over 150 years, this proximity built deep ties through trade, kinship, and godparenting (*compérage*), forging an integrated socio-political alliance in the Maritimes.

2. THE IMPERIAL NEUTRALITY PARADOX: UTRECHT & CONDITIONAL OATHS

Under the **1713 Treaty of Utrecht**, France ceded "Acadia with its ancient boundaries" to Great Britain. However, the treaty left borders dangerously ambiguous: Britain claimed all of modern Nova Scotia, New Brunswick, and eastern Maine, while France maintained that "Acadia" encompassed only the peninsular portion of Nova Scotia, retaining control of Île Royale (Cape Breton) and Île Saint-Jean (Prince Edward Island).

THE CHOPPY WATERS OF ACADIAN NEUTRALITY

British Garrison at Annapolis Royal (Few troops, isolated, vulnerable)

▼ Demands Unconditional Oath of Allegiance (Serment d'Allégeance)

Acadians Refuse: Refuse to bear arms against French or their Mi'kmaq relatives

▼ 1729–1730 Compromise: Governor Richard Philipps

The "Conditional Oath": Acadians pledge fidelity to the British Crown on the explicit, verbal condition that they are exempted from bearing arms in any future war.

▼

The "French Neutrals" (Les Français Neutres)

For 25 years, Acadians operate under de facto autonomy: supplying agricultural grain, governing locally through elected deputies, and trading with both Boston and Louisbourg.

To British imperial administrators in Halifax and Boston, this conditional neutrality was unacceptable. An independent, Catholic population with strong ties to Indigenous nations, living along key military waterways, was viewed as a significant security vulnerability as war with France approached.

3. THE ROAD TO WAR (1749–1754): CORNWALLIS & CHIGNECTO

In 1749, the British government moved to balance the French fortress of Louisbourg by establishing **Halifax**: a fortified naval and military base on Chebucto Bay.

Halifax was founded directly within *Eskikewa'kik*, an important Mi'kmaw hunting and coastal territory, without treaty, consultation, or compensation. The Santu Mawi'omi and Wabanaki leadership recognized the fort as an explicit encroachment, leading to the outbreak of the Anglo-Micmac War (Father Le Loutre's War, 1749–1755).

Date / Escalation Marker	British Imperial Action	Mi'kmaw / Acadian Counter-Action
June 1749	Edward Cornwallis arrives with 2,500 military settlers; founds Halifax.	Mi'kmaq send formal diplomatic letter warning against illegal settlement.
October 2, 1749	Cornwallis issues the Scalp Proclamation: £10 bounty for every Mi'kmaw person killed or captured.	Mi'kmaq and French-aligned Acadians target British supply lines and garrisons.
1750 – 1751	British build Fort Lawrence on the Chignecto Isthmus.	Father Jean-Louis Le Loutre encourages Acadians to relocate across the Missaguash River to French-held territory.
1753 – 1754	Charles Lawrence appointed Lieutenant-Governor; allies with New England mercantile factions.	Acadian deputies petition for reaffirmation of their historical conditional neutrality.

The Scalp Proclamation of October 1749

Governor Cornwallis's October 1749 proclamation authorized British forces to *"annoy, distress, take or destroy the Savage commonly called Mic-macks, wherever they are found"*, offering a cash bounty for every captive or scalp taken. This directive institutionalized irregular violence across the frontier and eliminated opportunities for diplomatic compromise in the province.

4. THE SIEGE OF FORT BEAUSÉJOUR: JUNE 1755

The border along the Missaguash River at the Chignecto Isthmus became the primary flashpoint in 1755. Facing Fort Lawrence stood the French star-fort, **Fort Beauséjour**, under the command of Louis Du Pont Duchambon de Vergor.

THE CHIGNECTO MILITARY EXPEDITION

May 1755: 2,000 New England provincial troops embark from Boston under Lt. Col. Robert Monckton



▼ June 2, 1755: Flotilla anchors in the Cumberland Basin
Siege operations begin against Fort Beauséjour



— Vergor forcibly conscripts ~300 local Acadian men under pain of death



▼ June 16, 1755: Mortar shell breaches the fort's bombproof shelter; Vergor surrenders



THE PRETEXT CREATED:

British forces find armed Acadians inside the captured French garrison. Despite Acadian testimony confirming they were forced to take up arms under threat of execution, Governor Charles Lawrence uses this as political justification to declare the entire Acadian population combatants and traitors.

5. THE HALIFAX COUNCIL OF JULY 1755: THE EXPULSION ORDER

With Fort Beauséjour captured, French naval power in the Bay of Fundy neutralized, and British Admiral Edward Boscawen’s fleet patrolling the coast, Lieutenant-Governor Charles Lawrence moved to settle the Acadian question permanently.

In July 1755, Acadian community deputies from Grand-Pré, Pisiguit, Annapolis Royal, and Beaubassin were summoned to appear before the Halifax Council. Lawrence delivered a final, non-negotiable ultimatum: **swear an unconditional oath of allegiance to King George II, including bearing arms in the King's service, or face immediate forfeiture of all lands and property.**

Extract from the Minutes of the Nova Scotia Council

Halifax, Monday, 28th July, 1755 • Present:
Lawrence, Boscawen, Mostyn

"The Deputies were then called in, and asked what they had to say regarding the Oath... They unanimously declared that they would not take the Oath of Allegiance without the condition formerly promised them, that they should not be obliged to bear arms against their countrymen or the French."

"They were then told, that they must take the consequences of their refusal... Whereupon they were ordered into custody."

Resolution: *"The Council, having maturely considered the whole affair, were unanimously of opinion, that it would be very dangerous to permit them to continue in the country; and that, in order to prevent their causing any further mischief, it was necessary to send them away out of the Province."*

The Motive of Land Speculation

Historical documents confirm that Lawrence and his New England merchant allies (including influential provisioning contractors like John Hancock’s uncle, Thomas Hancock) had financial incentives beyond border security. The Acadians had engineered over **100,000 acres of fertile, ready-to-farm salt marshes**. Deporting the population freed this productive land for redistribution to Protestant New England settlers ("The Planters"), while the military contracts to charter, supply, and feed the deportation fleet generated substantial profits for Boston merchant firms.

6. THE ENCLOSURE AT GRAND-PRÉ: WINSLOW'S DECREE

To execute the deportation order in the Minas Basin without triggering a general uprising, British Lieutenant-Colonel **John Winslow** deployed a strategy of deception at Grand-Pré.

Winslow arrived with 300 New England provincial troops, establishing camp around the stone church of **Saint-Charles-des-Mines**. On September 2, 1755, an official summons was posted ordering all Acadian men and boys over the age of ten to assemble in the church on Friday, September 5, to hear a directive from King George II.

THE DECREE OF SEPTEMBER 5, 1755

418 Unarmed Acadian Men and Boys Enter Saint-Charles-des-Mines

▼ Winslow Posts Armed Guards with Fixed Bayonets at All Exits

The Reading of the Expulsion Order (Winslow's Journal Entry):

"That your Lands & Tennements, Cattle of all Kinds and Live Stock of all Sortes are Forfeited to the Crown with all other your Effects Saving your money and Household Goods, and you Yourselfes to be Removed out of this his Province."

Mass Confinement:

The church is converted into an armed detention center. Outside, wives, mothers, and daughters are forced to prepare rations while watching their men marched to the transports under armed guard.

John Winslow's Personal Journal Entry

Grand-Pré, September 5, 1755

"Thus Ended the Memorable fifth of September, a Day of Great Perplexity and Trouble to the Inhabitants of this District, but an Absolute Duty Incumbent on me, agreeable to the Orders I had Received... It was indeed a scene of much Grief and Sollicitude."

7. SCORCHED EARTH LOGISTICS: FLOTILLAS OF EXILE

To ensure displaced Acadians could not return to their homes, Winslow, Monckton, and Major John Handfield executed a scorched-earth campaign across Grand-Pré, Pisiguit, Cobequid, and Chignecto. Barns, houses, mills, and churches were systematically burned, dykes were breached to salt the fields, and livestock was seized by the British military.

Settlement District	Houses / Barns Burned	Livestock Seized	Primary Deportation Destinations
Grand-Pré / Minas Basin	255 Houses, 276 Barns, 11 Mills, 1 Church	1,269 Cattle, 493 Horses, 2,620 Sheep, 897 Hogs	Pennsylvania, Virginia, Maryland, Massachusetts
Pisiguit (Windsor / Falmouth)	Over 180 Structures Burned	Substantial dairy herds slaughtered for garrison meat	Maryland, North Carolina, England
Chignecto / Beaubassin	Entire district leveled (250+ farmsteads)	Dispersed or driven to Fort Cumberland/Lawrence	South Carolina, Georgia, New York
Annapolis Royal (Port-Royal)	Over 100 homesteads destroyed along the river	Seized for the Annapolis Royal garrison	Connecticut, Massachusetts, England

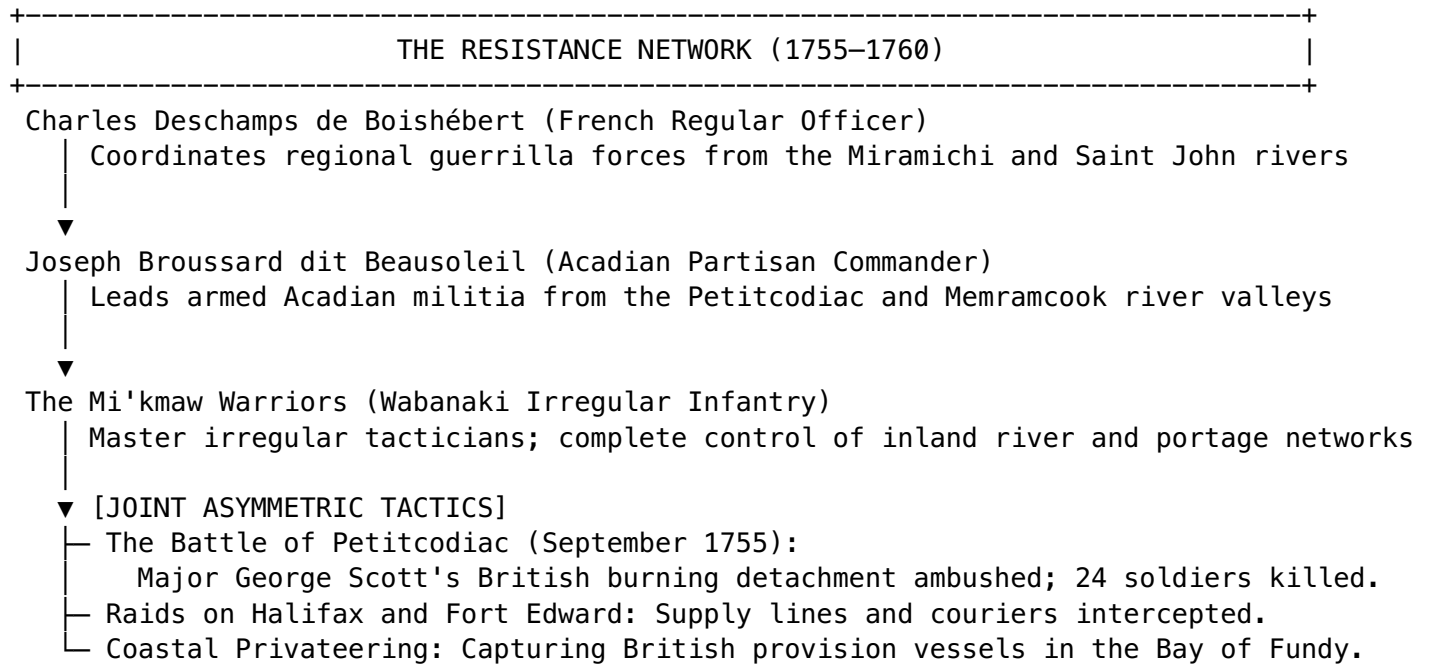
The Transport Ships: Maritime Losses

The logistical execution of the deportation was chaotic and hazardous. Colonial charter vessels (often small sloops and schooners designed for cargo, not passengers) were severely overcrowded to maximize profit:

- Rations & Overcrowding:** The military allowance of two passengers per ton was routinely exceeded. Families were separated in the confusion on the beaches, with parents placed on ships bound for Georgia while children were transported to Massachusetts or New York.
- Disease & Shipwrecks:** Typhus, smallpox, and dysentery broke out in the holds. Several transport ships foundered at sea with heavy loss of life; during the second wave in 1758, the transport vessels *Duke William* and *Violet* sank in the North Atlantic, drowning over 700 Acadians.

8. THE ASYMMETRIC DEFENSE: BEAUSOLEIL & THE MI'KMAW ALLIANCE

The deportation was met with sustained guerrilla resistance. Thousands of Acadians escaped into the northern forests of modern New Brunswick and eastern Quebec, joining forces with Mi'kmaq warriors to contest British control.



For five years, this allied resistance tied down British battalions and naval assets, preventing complete pacification of the region until after the fall of Quebec (1759) and the capitulation of Montreal (1760).

9. ARCHIVAL RECORDS & THE LANDRY LINEAGE

Among the primary Acadian families documented in the 1755 rolls was the **Landry** lineage, descended from René Landry *l'aîné* and René Landry *le jeune*, who settled in Port-Royal in the mid-17th century.

By 1755, the Landry family was heavily concentrated across Grand-Pré, Pisiguit, and the Chignecto Isthmus, functioning as community deputies, master carpenters, and dykebuilders.

Extract: John Winslow’s Grand-Pré Detention Roster

September 1755 • Captive Acadian Heads of Household (Landry Line)

Name Listed ogs	Sons	Daughters	Cattle	Horses	Sheep	H

Landry, Jean (Minas) 14	3	4	12	4	35	
Landry, René (Grand-Pré) 10	5	2	18	3	42	
Landry, Germain (Pisiguit) 8	2	5	14	2	28	
Landry, Pierre (River Canard) 16	4	3	20	5	50	
Landry, François (Minas) 6	1	3	8	2	15	

Note: The Landry family was broken up across multiple transport vessels. Branches were deported to Maryland, Pennsylvania, and Massachusetts; others escaped into the forests of northern New Brunswick, eventually resettling in the Miramichi, Madawaska, and Louisiana (giving rise to Cajun culture).

The Dispossession Ledger

The land registries of Nova Scotia show that within a decade of the 1755 deportation, Acadian dykelands were surveyed, subdivided, and granted to New England Planter syndicates. However, without Acadian knowledge of maintaining the *clapet* valves and repairing sod walls, large portions of the dykes breached during the major storms of 1759, causing saltwater to flood the marshes and delaying new settlement for years.

10. UNBROKEN TITLE & THE TREATIES OF PEACE AND FRIENDSHIP

The historical events of 1755 remain legally and politically relevant in Canada today. Unlike other parts of North America, the Maritime provinces were never surrendered through land-cession treaties.

The **Treaties of Peace and Friendship** signed between the British Crown and the Mi'kmaq, Maliseet, and Passamaquoddy nations (in 1725, 1752, and 1760–1761) did not cede Indigenous sovereignty, surrender lands, or extinguish Aboriginal title:

- **Supreme Court of Canada Affirmation (R. v. Marshall, 1999):** The highest court confirmed that the Treaties of Peace and Friendship remain binding constitutional documents guaranteeing Mi'kmaq commercial harvesting and self-governance rights.
- **Acadian Survivance:** Despite the forced dispersal of over 10,000 Acadians between 1755 and 1763, surviving communities returned to the Maritimes following the 1764 lifting of the deportation orders, re-establishing vibrant Acadian regions across south-western Nova Scotia (Clare, Argyle), Cape Breton (Isle Madame, Chéticamp), Prince Edward Island, and northern New Brunswick.

